

St. Joseph the All Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 6, Nov 8/21 2020, Archangel Michael and all the Heavenly Bodiless Powers

Table of Contents

Contact Info	1
The Nativity fast	2
St John Chrysostom on True Fasting	3
Fasting is a help to us; we should approach fasts with the expectation of spiritual improvement.	3
Spiritual and physical effects of Fasting.	3
Real Fasting: from meat and sins.	3
Why do we fast after the Sunday of the Publican and Pharisee?	4
Admonition - Dost thou fast? Give me proof of it by thy works!	4
Fasting for all the senses explained	4
Questions & Answers	4
A Word from Fr. Seraphim	5
Pastoral Letter	5
The World is getting Darker	5
Local Spiritual effects & dangers of the Pandemic	5
What WILL you do? Are you ready?	6
Things we all must change.	7
Daily Prayer Rule	7
Read the Psalter!	7
Read the Scriptures!	7
Increase attendance in the Services.	7
You are of the Royal Priesthood! Act like a priest!	7
Your life is not your own!	8
Struggle aggressively in everything!	8
A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 8-10	8

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-006_2020-11-21+nativity-fast-why-fast-pastoral-letter-pray-aloud.html

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-006_2020-11-21+nativity-fast-why-fast-pastoral-letter-pray-aloud.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-006_2020-11-21+nativity-fast-why-fast-pastoral-letter-pray-aloud.doc

Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter on at least the first and the 15th of each month. This is the 6th sent to 75 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at

<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Contact Info

Patriarch Joseph the All Comely Texas ORTHODOX Prison Ministry
<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net, St. Nicholas Russian Orthodox Church, PO Box 37, McKinney, TX 75070

Priest Cassian Sibley frcassian@yahoo.com, Theotokos of the Life-Giving Spring Russian Orthodox Mission, 1009 Winter Street, Bryan, TX 77803

Priest David Companik davidcompanik@gmail.com, St. Jonah Orthodox Church, PO Box 1427, Spring, TX 77383

NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need these lines.

The Nativity fast

The Nativity fast begins on Nov 15, every year. This year, it is two days after Thanksgiving. That means that we can consider the fast to start the day after Thanksgiving for all practical purposes, which of course is a Friday.

It is very normal in Christian tradition to prepare ourselves for important feasts. There is a fasting period before the major feasts of the Christian year – Pascha (Easter), and Nativity (Christmas), and also before the Dormition (falling asleep of the Theotokos), and the Feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul. We also fast on most Wednesdays and Fridays of the year.

Each fast differs a little bit in “character” and rigor. The Nativity Fast is one of joyful expectation and is one of the easiest of the long fasts. Here are the “rules”.

On all days of the fast, we do not eat any (land or air) “animal product” - beef, chicken, pork, etc., or their “products” – cheese, eggs, milk, etc. We also do not eat fish, wine, and olive oil on all weekdays. On weekends, we may have fish, wine, and oil. There are lots of exceptions based upon which saint is celebrated on the calendar. Foods that are allowed on any day include sea life that is not fish, that does not have fins, such as shrimp, or clams, vegetables, fruit, bread, beans, lentils, honey, and if you happen to be in Uganda, feel free to partake of the fried grasshoppers; they are delicious (insects are not considered to be “animal products”). I loved them when I was there; however, I would advise you not to eat them the first time on a long boat trip on Lake Victoria because they can be rather stimulating to a gut that is not accustomed to them.

Of course, in prison, food choices are limited. Everybody has different spiritual and physical abilities. You should talk to me (or Fr David) or write if you have any questions. The most important question that you must answer regarding fasting is not what you should eat, but why you should fast. If you don’t know the reason why you fast, then you will not profit from fasting. Even a person who fasts poorly will benefit from fasting if they understand why they are fasting and have a goal.

In general, it is excellent to avoid meat (beef, chicken, pork, “mystery meat”) during the fast and supplement your diet with whatever you can get at the commissary, such as peanut butter and beans. I understand that not everyone can make commissary, and there may be medical reasons why you need certain foods, and therefore it is always good to talk to the

priest. The fast is not a set of rules that you must follow “or else” – it is a spiritual exercise in which the body helps the soul (and as is always the case when the body helps the soul, the soul helps the body).

Anyone who has fasted for any length of time should be able to discern some of the benefits. They come over time, and it is very difficult, if not impossible, to make significant progress in the spiritual life without some fasting.

We must be honest, not only with others but especially with ourselves. The honest man, who knows himself, knows that we are by nature inclined to selfishness and self-indulgence, and forgetfulness about God. Fasting acts directly against these latter two tendencies. We choose to **not** indulge ourselves for God’s sake, and by choosing to keep a fast (and trying to pray more than we usually do and read spiritual things too), we are less likely to be forgetful. Fasting acts indirectly against selfishness because a forgetful self-indulgent person is always selfish.

Fasting has other great benefits, which you must experience to understand. We put food “in its place,” as something that we need to survive, but not particularly important for pleasure. We have all heard the adage that we should “eat to live and not live to eat.” For a Christian, life is communion with God and not pleasure from the senses. By no means are we against pleasurable things because God gives them to man; however, all beauty and pleasure in the world have but one goal – that we would see God in all things and love Him.

You should always increase your prayer during fasting periods. If we were holy, we would ever “pray without ceasing” (1 Thes5:17) in obedience to the apostle’s command. However, we are not holy, and we need to take every advantage of the fasting seasons to remind us to pray more. We cannot focus on God as an anchorite in the desert, but we can, if we *want* to, focus more completely on God during the fasting seasons.

The person who follows the fasts with even a moderate degree of precision will discover that they feel lighter and more energetic. The thinking becomes clearer, and those unfortunate times when we overeat and feel weighed down and unable to do anything except wallow until our food is digested disappear or at least become less numerous.

I am asking you to fast as you are able and to expect God to help you learn things about yourself and

Him during your fast. Fasting is a little bit like taking blinders off – we see things more clearly – both good and bad. You may learn some things about yourself – positive and negative. You may be able to pray more or perhaps have trouble praying. Even this latter condition may be beneficial to you because we always have trouble praying because of something in ourselves that is blocking our prayer.

We are on the road to perfection, made possible because of the perfect life of the God-man, Jesus Christ; This takes effort, and fasting has always been shown to help us in this task. We fast to improve in the essential virtue – Love. A careful examination of ourselves will show us that when we are not loving, it is always because there is some selfishness or intemperance in us. Fasting teaches us the self-control necessary to learn to love as God loves. Priest Seraphim

St John Chrysostom on True Fasting

This is a long quotation but very profitable to read. The language is a little bit archaic because it's from an old translation, but plow through it, and you will reap many benefits. He emphasizes that fasting is not just what you do not eat, but what you do and don't do to and for your fellow man. It explains the purpose of fasting, the proper attitude towards it, its effects on our spiritual state, and how fasting not done in the right spirit is injurious. We also see from St John's words the reason we have a fast-free week following the Sunday of the Publican and Pharisee. He does not reference this custom, but his explanation is the reason it exists. The homily from which this quotation was taken has many other profitable things about fasting. St John Chrysostom, Letters; Homilies on the Statutes, Homily III, (https://www.documentacatholicaomnia.eu/03d/0345-0407,_Iohannes_Chrysostomus,_Homilies_on_Statutes,_EN.pdf)

Fasting is a help to us; we should approach fasts with the expectation of spiritual improvement.

7. Let us not then despair of our safety, but let us pray; let us make invocation; let us supplicate; let us go on an embassy to the King that is above with many tears! **We have this fast too as an ally and as an assistant in this good intercession.**

Therefore, as when the winter is over, and the summer is appearing, the sailor draws his vessel to the deep, and the soldier burnishes his arms, and makes ready his steed for the battle; and the husbandman sharpens his sickle; and the traveler boldly undertakes a long journey, and the wrestler strips and bares himself for the contest.

So too, when the fast makes its appearance, like a kind of spiritual summer, let us as soldiers burnish our weapons; and as husbandmen let us sharpen our sickle; and as sailors let us order our thoughts against the waves of extravagant desires; and as travelers let us set out on the journey towards heaven; and as wrestlers let us strip for the contest. For the believer is at once a husbandman, and a sailor, and a soldier, a wrestler, and a traveler.

Hence St. Paul saith, "We wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers. Put on therefore the whole armour of God." Eph. vi. 12.

Hast thou observed the wrestler? Hast thou observed the soldier? If thou art a wrestler, it is necessary for thee to engage in the conflict naked. If a soldier, it behooves thee to stand in the battle line armed at all points. How then are both these things possible, to be naked, and yet not naked; to be clothed, and yet not clothed! How? I will tell thee. Divest thyself of worldly business, and thou hast become a wrestler. Put on the spiritual amour, and thou hast become a soldier. Strip thyself of worldly cares, for the season is one of wrestling. Clothe thyself with the spiritual amour, for we have a heavy warfare to wage with demons. Therefore, also it is needful we should be naked, so as to offer nothing that the devil may take hold of, while he is wrestling with us; and to be fully armed at all points, so as on no side to receive a deadly blow.

Cultivate thy soul.

Cut away the thorns.

Sow the word of godliness.

Propagate and nurse with much care the fair plants of divine wisdom, and thou hast become a husbandman.

And Paul will say to thee, "The husbandman that laboureth must be first partaker of the fruits." 2 Tim. ii. 6. He too himself practiced this art. Therefore, writing to the Corinthians, he said, "I have planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the increase." 1 Cor. iii. 6

Spiritual and physical effects of Fasting.

Sharpen thy sickle, which thou hast blunted through gluttony—sharpen it by fasting. Lay hold of the pathway which leads towards heaven; rugged and narrow as it is, lay hold of it, and journey on.

And how mayest thou be able to do these things? By subduing thy body, and bringing it into subjection. For when the way grows narrow, the corpulence that comes of gluttony is a great hindrance.

Keep down the waves of inordinate desires.

Repel the tempest of evil thoughts.

Preserve the boat; display much skill, and thou hast become a pilot.

But we shall have the fast for a groundwork and instructor in all these things.

Real Fasting: from meat and sins.

8. I speak not, indeed, of such a fast as most persons keep, but of real fasting; not merely an abstinence from meats; but from sins too. For the nature of a fast is such, that it does not suffice to deliver those who practice it, unless it be done according

to a suitable law. "For the wrestler," it is said, "is not crowned unless he strive lawfully." 2 Tim. ii. 5.

Why do we fast after the Sunday of the Publican and Pharisee?

To the end then, that when we have gone through the labor of fasting, we forfeit not the crown of fasting, we should understand how, and after what manner, it is necessary to conduct this business; since **that Pharisee also fasted**, Luke xviii. 12. **but afterwards went down empty, and destitute of the fruit of fasting.** The Publican fasted not; and yet he was accepted in preference to him who had fasted; in order that thou **mayest learn that fasting is unprofitable, except all other duties follow with it.**

The Ninevites fasted, and won the favor of God. Jonah 3:10. The Jews, fasted too, and profited nothing, nay, they departed with blame. Isa. lviii. 3, 7; 1 Cor. ix. 26.

Since then the danger in fasting is so great to those who do not know how they ought to fast, we should learn the laws of this exercise, in order that we may not "run uncertainly," nor "beat the air," nor while we are fighting contend with a shadow.

Fasting is a medicine; but a medicine, though it be never so profitable, becomes frequently useless owing to the unskilfulness of him who employs it. For it is necessary to know, moreover, the time when it should be applied, and the requisite quantity of it; and the temperament of body that admits it; and the nature of the country, and the season of the year; and the corresponding diet; as well as various other particulars; any of which, if one overlooks, he will mar all the rest that have been named. Now if, when the body needs healing, such exactness is required on our part, much more ought we, when our care is about the soul, and we seek to heal the distempers of the mind, to look, and to search into every particular with the utmost accuracy.

Admonition - Dost thou fast? Give me proof of it by thy works!

11. I have said these things, not that we may disparage fasting, but that we may honor fasting; for the honor of fasting consists not in abstinence from food, but in withdrawing from sinful practices; since he who limits his fasting only to an abstinence from meats, is one who especially disparages it.

Dost thou fast? Give me proof of it by thy works!

Is it said by what kind of works?

If thou seest a poor man, take pity on him!

If thou seest in enemy, be reconciled to him!

If thou seest a friend gaining honor, envy him not!

If thou seest a handsome woman, pass her by!

For let not the mouth only fast, but also the eye, and the ear, and the feet, and the hands, and all the members of our bodies.

Let the hands fast, by being pure from rapine and avarice.

Let the feet fast, by ceasing from running to the unlawful spectacles.

Let the eyes fast, being taught never to fix themselves rudely upon handsome countenances, or to busy themselves with strange beauties.

Fasting for all the senses explained

For looking is the food of the eyes, but if this be such as is unlawful or forbidden, it mars the fast; and upsets the whole safety of the soul; but if it be lawful and safe, it adorns fasting. For it would be among things the most absurd to abstain from lawful food because of the fast, but with the eyes to touch even what is forbidden. Dost thou not eat flesh? Feed not upon lasciviousness by means of the eyes.

Let the ear fast also. The fasting of the ear consists in refusing to receive evil speakings and calumnies. "Thou shalt not receive a false report," it says.

12. Let the mouth too fast from disgraceful speeches and railing. For what doth it profit if we abstain from birds and fishes; and yet bite and devour our brethren? The evil speaker eateth the flesh of his brother, and biteth the body of his neighbor.

Because of this Paul utters the fearful saying, "If ye bite and devour one another, take heed that ye be not consumed one of another." Gal. 5:15 Thou hast not fixed thy teeth in the flesh, but thou hast fixed the slander in the soul and inflicted the wound of evil suspicion; thou hast harmed, in a thousand ways, thyself and him, and many others, for in slandering a neighbor thou hast made him who listens to the slander worse...

This document is at: <http://www.orthodox.net/articles/true-fasting-saint-john-chrysostom.html>

Questions & Answers

Praying aloud in my cell.

My question is fairly straightforward: How accommodating should I be for a cellmate who doesn't like it when I pray?

A little background. I am in AD-SEG for medical reasons, so I don't have a cellmate at such; I have a neighbor who can hear me, however. He's new. My old neighbor liked the prayers, LOL. In any

case, one of the few perks to being in AD-SEG is relative privacy to pray throughout the day. My habit (not rule, but preference) is to say a canon and Akathist during the day, especially on Wed/Fri. my new neighbor finds this annoying and complains. Do I stop doing the extra prayers?

I'm not willing to drop my morning and evening prayers: those are my "non-negotiables" (see, I read the columns :-). I am trying to whisper them, but he still complains. What should I do?

My advice to the prisoner would be to pray noetically – pray silently but cross yourself and make the requisite prostrations, etc. There is no point in provoking the wrath of men that so seldom works the will of God – but there's no reason to stop praying either! (By the way – that reminds me of an odd fact. St. Augustine is reputed to have been the first person in history to have read silently – it was so odd that it was frequently commented upon by

his contemporaries, who sometimes likened it to a kind of magic – he could read without moving his lips! The fact that reading was always verbalized in the classical and early Christian era contributed to the idea that thought and language – noesis and logos – were completely distinct. So, the recitation of prayers silently was seen as something different from the reading of those prayers – since to read them one had to verbalize them, but to "think" them, or "pray them noetically," one didn't. In short, this sharp distinction between the two activities generally seems odd to us, but was quite natural to them!)

Fr. Cassian

A Word from Fr. Seraphim

The following is a pastoral letter that I wrote to my parish. The vast majority of it applies directly to anybody, including those in prison. It has a lot of advice for living the spiritual life day-to-day. Even though I talk about coming to services regularly, which obviously you cannot do in prison, when we do come to see you, you can apply your "Royal priesthood", and always show up. It's always sad to me when I find out that someone didn't come because they felt like sleeping or whatever. Do not listen to the whispers of the evil one! Everything you do is essential, including just showing up.

Pastoral Letter

Oct 26/ Nov 8, 2020, Holy and Great Martyr Demetrius of Thessalonica

To my beloved flock:

I have some essential things to say to you. This letter began when I was sitting on the porch of a cabin in Oklahoma. Getting away for a day or two allows one to think a little bit, pray, and have things resonate in one's soul. Sometimes, things are too loud for us to have an extended moment of introspection in our daily lives. I was able to do this when vacationing with my family in Broken Bow, Oklahoma. The first morning, Fr. Nicholas and I were walking on the road and speaking of pastoral things. We were talking about how there have been very great difficulties during this pandemic. Later in the day, although I was on vacation, I was feeling stressed because of all the things that had been going on and did not feel well enough to go to the park, so I stayed back with some others, took a nap, and sat in a rocking chair and prayed and read. Then I dictated the beginnings of this letter.

I suppose someone expert in writing would say that my introduction should be expunged because it does not contain anything of the message that I want to convey to you. I would disagree. We are human beings, and we go through problems, and we must find a way to persevere. Father Nicholas and I are just like you. We have our concerns and worries, and sometimes we have good days, and sometimes we have bad days. The difficulties of the priesthood have trained me always to attack problems with aggressiveness. This aggressiveness can be prayer, fasting, or doing something I don't want to do, but I force myself to do it. I want you to be aggressive when there are problems in your life. I don't want you to be passive about anything the troubles you. I am aggressive in this letter because I'm quite worried.

The World is getting Darker

My heart is very heavy. I am very concerned, even anxious about the future for my flock. The reason for this is because there is not enough zeal among us. The world is getting darker, and our country is becoming wrapped in chains. I'm not speaking politically here. In our political age, almost everyone thinks everything is political. I began this letter before the November election. The problems of our country and the world are not political; they are moral. Do not think that you are immune to immorality and the abyss into which our society is heading.

I don't think anything will stop this progression (certainly not an election, no matter who is elected). If we read history, we see that there have been many times when the church has been furiously persecuted. There is persecution now. It is not so much persecution of our flesh, not yet. But our minds are being oppressed, and some of you are falling prey to this persecution. We are in a secular age, with hateful and diabolical rhetoric, and hearts are cold. We are concerned about material things and the hubbub of life, and we don't think enough about spiritual things.

Local Spiritual effects & dangers of the Pandemic

When the pandemic began, there was a particular zeal, and people wanted to go to church even if they could not. We had Zoom meetings, and there was a lot of involvement by most of the parish. Since that time, it's been a very long, difficult road. For many of you, your zeal has worn off. Our attendance at Divine Liturgy and the vigil service is smaller. We probably do not even need to have a Vespers and then a Vigil service. We can accommodate everyone in just a Vigil service, which is not attended by enough of you.

What do you think you are doing, my flock? Don't you realize that the times that you are in now are going to change? Don't you understand that the Leviathan might devour you if you do not live zealously now? Do you know what I mean by the Leviathan? I don't mean a demonic beast. I mean that your heart will be cold, and the world will influence you. And the world will be telling you that you can be a Christian as long as you don't act like one or don't believe like one and you make concessions to the world. Are you ready for this?

Are you asleep? I've told friends recently that I'm not "woke," and the reason is that since I have become a Christian, I have never been asleep! As an Orthodox Christian and even though I am a sinner, but also as a priest, how can I be sleeping if I serve the Holy Mysteries before the altar and if I pray for each of you every day?

Do you pray for one another every day? I think we know the answer to this question. Many of you do not pray very much, if at all. Many of you do not read the scriptures very much, if at all. Many of you go to the church haphazardly, and if you do come, your mind is on other things.

Do you think that you can survive the upcoming tsunami wave of unbelief and real persecution? I fear for many of you; perhaps some of you will not. I beg you as your pastor and as your spiritual father and as a sinner, a fellow sinner who needs the grace of God to warm his heart, that you would apply yourself more to the daily life of being a Christian. There is absolutely no good reason why all of you should not try to come to the vigil and confession and the liturgy. All the things that help us meet God during the liturgy are necessary also, such as fasting, praying daily, and struggling for virtue.

I understand that some are afraid of this virus (and some of you have well-thought-out reasons for your actions), but many of you are not so fearful of the virus, but it has nonetheless caused you to become accustomed to a lower way of living. I'm concerned for you because what you are doing now is not what you will be doing in two years. The dogs of hell are getting loose. Some have already been loosed upon our country. We live in an age when there is a belief in political solutions and slogans, lifestyle choices, and sexual orientation, but not so much in God. We live in an age when, even in a country that purports to be free, there is compelled speech or compelled silence. It doesn't matter what politics you hold, people are weak, and their hearts are cold. You will see it very soon, and you will know that we are losing our freedoms.

What WILL you do? Are you ready?

What will you do when you lose your freedom? Will you give in to the secular world? I think some of you will.

When the Bolsheviks persecuted the Christians of Russia, the majority of them "got along." There were many martyrs, in the millions and even perhaps tens of millions, but the majority "got along." Is that what you want to do? You will have significant decisions to make in the future regarding your employment, your worship, and your daily life. If you do not make your decisions now and aggressively live according to them, when the time comes, your choices will be made out of your personal weakness, and choices made out of personal weakness are never pleasing to God.

I speak to many of you in confession, and I ask, "How do you pray?" and "Do you read the Bible?". The answers are almost always very disappointing. You have freedom right now to pray, read the Bible, come to worship services, and even, in most places, to live absolutely according to your conscience. If you are not using these freedoms, then your soul is not free, no matter what the appearances.

You drink water every day, don't you? You have two or three meals a day, and even snacks, don't you? You make sure that you get enough sleep, don't you? You take care of your body, and you have the latest phone, and you have good Internet at your house and clean clothes without any tears in them.

What are you doing with your soul? Is it refreshed with the water of the Holy Spirit? Does it have enough food that does not perish? Is it awake or asleep? Are you providing for it more than you provide for the needs of your body?

I have looked out during many vigils, and I have been very sad because I have seen so few of you. You might be able to get away with that if life goes on like it's been. But life will not be as it is now. Things will change.

Are you ready? I don't know if I am ready. And of course, my liturgical life and prayer life, even though I am a sinner, is bigger than most of yours! I pray for you every day, and of course, I celebrate the liturgy, usually two times a week. And we have the vigil service and other services, and I'm not sure if I'm going to be ready.

The persecution will be fierce, and I am afraid for my children and my grandchildren. Am I ready to go to prison? Am I prepared to be deprived of food or shelter? Will I stand fast when the secular state tries to influence how I act as a pastor and as a Christian? During this pandemic, we have seen that the secular state in many places believes it can completely control whether services are served. What will I do if Christian services are outlawed? Whatever the pretense for them being made illegal, what will I do? Outlawing Christian services and assembly and even outlawing Christian thought has happened many times in the past. Do not think that we are immune to such persecutions.

I cannot tell you absolutely what my answer to these questions will be (how can anyone know how they will do in the test until they are tested?), but I can tell you how we must prepare to answer those questions in a way that saves our souls.

Many of you are not doing those things. May God bless you, and may God help you. Know that Fr. Nicholas and I, although we are just poor men, pray for you every day, and God hears those prayers. But if you don't pray and don't work on your virtues, then you will be drowned when the wave comes.

May God preserve and help you, and may God help you listen to this letter and hear it in the spirit in which it was written.

Things we all must change.

Here are some of the things that I want you to change.

Daily Prayer Rule

You must have a daily prayer rule! If you don't have a daily prayer rule that you are following to some degree, you are starving yourself. *You are literally committing suicide.* Are you suicidal? You might say, "No, I am not suicidal! How dare you accuse me!", but if you have life (that is, prayer, and the services and the struggle for virtue) before you and turn away from it, what else can that be called except suicide? I understand we have weaknesses, and sometimes miss our prayers, and that we get distracted. But if you don't have a rule that you are attempting to follow (and, preferably, telling Fr. Nicholas or me about it to hold you accountable and help you), you are turning away from life.

You must commit to a daily prayer rule. This daily prayer rule must include praying for many people who have crossed your path in your life. It should *not* be a very short list. And it should not be, as children will pray, where they only say, "Lord have mercy on my mommy and daddy and everyone!". We are not children! We should be those who put away childish things. We must pray for others.

Read the Psalter!

I also highly recommend the Psalter. Why do I recommend the Psalter? It is the way the church prays. It is hard to understand. I've read it for many years, and there are still phrases in there that I don't fully understand, but there is something in those phrases that is holy and that starts to permeate into my wretched soul and put light where there was formerly darkness. Read the Psalter! And if you have other prayers that you love, read those as well.

Perhaps you do not follow your prayer rule well. I don't care! All I care about is that you have a prayer rule that you **attempt** to follow. If you are doing this, then you will be able to follow it eventually. Please talk to Fr. Nicholas or me about

developing a prayer rule. I expect every single one of you will come to speak to one of us.

Read the Scriptures!

You must be reading the scriptures. I recommend that you read the Gospels. You can read other scriptures that are edifying. I am regularly reading the Psalter (every day!), Gospels, the Epistles, and the Old Testament wisdom books, and sometimes other books. You must be doing this! You must be gathering wisdom from the Word of God because the world is trying to impart to you its wisdom, and that is the wisdom of demons. Do not think yourself to be immune to this wisdom, even if you *think* you are rejecting it! This anti-truth, anti-Christ wisdom permeates our media and entertainment, politics, schools, businesses - almost everything, everywhere.

Increase attendance in the Services

The third thing that I beg you to do is to attend the services with more care. When I became an Orthodox Christian, it was as if I was a man who had been in the desert and without a drink for many days and finally had cool, clear water. I loved the services from the very beginning, and I always have. For many of you, the services are difficult. You get bored, and your feet hurt, and you have other things that you'd rather be doing. You might tell yourself that you barely pray during services anyway, so what is the use? You must train yourself to love the services! You will not learn this by staying home on a Saturday night and grilling or watching a television program or going to a movie or just doing whatever you do. I expect all of you to prioritize coming to the services, and if you don't, you are like that man who sees life and turns away from it: a suicidal person. I understand that there are times when you cannot come to the services, but if you do not want to go to them or if you miss them for reasons that are foolish and transitory, you are making your soul sick.

What are you to do if they bore you, or you cannot pay attention well, or you feel the stress of other things in your life and do not feel that you have the time? Do you like to do your taxes? I'm sure you do them. Perhaps you're late on them, but you do get them done because paying taxes is required of you as a citizen. You are a citizen of the Kingdom of Heaven. Some requirements are incumbent upon you because you are a citizen. And one of those requirements is to come to the services according to your ability (and be very honest about whether you can come!).

You are of the Royal Priesthood! Act like a priest!

I will tell you something that I learned many years ago. I'll be honest with you; nobody ever told me this.

For some reason, although I am a sinner, this was a kind of revelation given to me; it was something that I was very sure of

right after my baptism. Do you know that you are a “holy priesthood”? Yes, we have priests and deacons and bishops, and those who are not of those offices cannot do the things that God has ordained for the clergy to do, but *we are all of the royal priesthood*. God demands your presence in the liturgy and all of the services because you are a priest! A priest intercedes on behalf of the people to God, and God helps the people. Even if there are only one or two people in the service and you become the third person, you have caused God to give a great blessing to His people. You have interceded for God's people, and God hears that intercession, even just by your presence in the services and your attempt to pray.

Your life is not your own!

I am begging you to listen to what I am telling you and to start developing in your heart an absolute conviction that your life is not your own! You are bought with a price! You belong to God, and you are His slave. Your love for others should also make you a slave to love. Even if you don't understand it, and it does not resonate in your heart, prayer is what moves God for His people. Therefore, you must do everything you can. If you fast poorly, at least you can try to fast! If you cannot pray with great attention, at least you can stand in prayer! If you are not good at a prayer rule or have certain sins in your life, you can at least come to the services.

You are not an island! Your life is not your own! Your life belongs to your family and your parish and to anyone who crosses your path. Therefore, I am begging you that you would start coming to the services. I would be happy to serve a vigil at the hall and a vigil at the church if 80 people want to pray at the vigil. Now we don't even have 40. God may judge us for this.

Struggle aggressively in everything!

I want you to work on a fourth thing. I mention it last; however, one could consider it the first prerequisite to all spiritual exercises because it is the energy behind everything spiritual. ***If we have a strong, intense, and aggressive intention to struggle***, we will pray, fast, attend the services, and read the Scripture.

Suppose something is challenging for you. It could be a difficulty in your life, a frequently recurring sin, depression, sadness, sickness, or anything that upsets your soul. You must start to struggle against it. You must not just give in to it. You must aggressively work against your sins. Are you going to do that, or are you going to live a worldly life? Are you going to live like the grasshopper who thinks it is summertime all the time? When the winter came, the grasshopper starved.

May God help us. Please pray for me and remember that I pray for you. God bless you.

Unworthy Priest Seraphim Holland, who prays for the God-protected flock of St Nicholas Orthodox Church, McKinney Texas
(*and everyone in our shared prison ministry diptychs*)

Phone: 972 658-5433 Email: seraphim@orthodox.net
http://www.orthodox.net/announcements/pastoral-letter_2020-11-08.pdf
http://www.orthodox.net/announcements/pastoral-letter_2020-11-08.doc
http://www.orthodox.net/announcements/pastoral-letter_2020-11-08.html

A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 8-10

From "A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life," Hieroconfessor Alexander (Orlov) Of Omsk, who fell asleep in 1977 at the age of 99, translated by Protopresbyter Thomas Marretta. These gems of spiritual wisdom are sent in email messages from my good friend, Fr Demetrios Carellas. We will investigate getting copies of this book to send to many of you. (Priest Seraphim)

8. Drink Holy Water with thirst and longing, so that you may be sanctified, body and soul.

9. Repeat constantly, or at least hourly, the Angel's greeting to the Queen of Heaven: "Rejoice, Virgin Theotokos, Mary full of Grace, the Lord is with thee; blessed art thou among women

and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, for thou hast borne the Savior of our souls."

10. During your free time, read the Holy Fathers and the teachers of the spiritual life. If you do not have their books, borrow them from someone who does. (The lives of the Saints are also great reads.)